

investors, he set up the pretentiously named Royal Academy of Music, at the King's Theatre in Haymarket, touring Europe to recruit the most famous singers, including castrato Senesino (see [box](#)), soprano Francesca Cuzzoni, and mezzo-soprano Faustina Bordoni. Managing these superstars was never easy. It is said that once, frustrated by her refusal to sing an aria he had written, Handel threatened to throw Cuzzoni out of a window. But the performances Handel put on at the King's Theatre became, for a time, the most fashionable entertainments in London. His celebrated operas of this period include *Ottone* (1723), *Giulio Cesare* (1724), and *Tamerlano* (1724).

From operas to oratorios

In the late 1720s, Handel's operatic enterprise ran into problems. The popular success of John Gay's lively English-language music drama *The Beggar's Opera*, staged in 1728, deflated the vogue for Italian opera. Bankrupted by the huge fees paid to its star singers, the Royal Academy of Music folded. In 1734, Handel abandoned the theatrical business, although he continued to write operas, mostly staged at the new Covent Garden theater, until 1741.

The decline in the fashion for Italian opera led Handel to move into writing oratorios. These large-scale sacred concert pieces for soloists, orchestra, and choir proved hugely popular. Selecting biblical themes and setting English-language texts, he appealed to British patriotism and Protestantism. *Esther*, presented as part of the opera season in 1732, was followed by more than 20 oratorios over the next two decades. The most famous, *Messiah*, was first